

Android: The developer speak

As it is open source, Android is supposed to be a mobile application developer's dream. Ilya A. Eliashevsky, product manager, DataViz (developers of Road Sync and Documents to Go), has so far been impressed by Android and feels that the fact that the OS is open source makes application development faster for it. "The open source concept is slightly new to our efforts and we are currently in the process of determining how to best leverage its full potential. One example where we quickly realised the benefit was when we recently used code from the open source community to develop a RoadSync Calendar application on Android. In this case, we were able to dramatically reduce our development costs and more quickly provide consumers a feature rich solution that had previously taken much longer to develop on other platforms. I think the same speed to market and lower cost concepts hold true for open source across the entire mobile food chain—from OS providers, to device manufacturers, to operators and developers," he says.

The 'open'ness of Android also appeals to David Storey, developer relations, Opera, developers of the Opera Mobile and Opera Mini browsers. "We have great respect for the open source movement and our products run on various open source platforms. If websites and browsers are created based on open standards, you get an ideal environment for innovation on all platforms and devices, including mobiles," he says. However, he feels that Android will represent a good business opportunity when more devices come out and are adopted by users.

The interface is based on version 1.5 of Android, also known as Cupcake. The homescreen seems pretty stark to start off, with the huge clock at the top and four icons below, but there is a whole lot of magic (pun intended) lying beneath it. You can customise the home screen (which spans three screens that slide to either side) by simply dragging and dropping items from the menu. You can place an item just about anywhere (and we mean *anywhere*) on the homescreen—there are no restrictions at all. And if you don't like an item, just keep it pressed and then drag it into the handy rubbish bin that appears on the bottom of the screen. Incidentally, you can access the menu by either hitting the *Menu* button or sliding up the bar at the bottom of the homescreen—we found the latter to be much more fun. You can get back to the homescreen at any time by hitting the *Home* button or to the previous screen by pressing (you guessed it) the *Back* button.

All of which makes the HTC Magic perhaps one of the most intuitive touchscreen devices we have come across. The icons in the menu are large enough to be pressed by your finger, while texting and e-mailing addicts will be delighted to know that the onscreen QWERTY keypad is a treat in landscape as well as portrait mode, with an excellent predictive text facility to boot.

Terrific browser, great notification bar...

The phone comes with the standard smartphone software. There is a contacts manager, a calendar, an e-mail client, a document reader (QuickOffice) and other software, but the application that just leapt out and grabbed our attention was the browser. When it comes to browsing the Internet, we had been under the impression that Safari on the iPhone and Opera Mobile on Windows Mobile were as good as they get. Well, the Magic made us change our minds. The Internet browser on the device is very powerful and renders pages at a decent speed while giving one far more control over the content—you can tweak just about any setting, from Javascript and Google Gears to images, with minimum fuss. And yes, Web pages do look gorgeous on that large touchscreen. True, there is no support for Flash yet, but apart from that, we have no hesitation in putting the browser alongside Safari and Opera Mobile.

Yet, even the browser is overshadowed by the excellent notification bar that runs on top of the screen, which alerts you about new e-mails and text messages that have come in. It makes the SMS/e-mail preview feature on some Nokia devices look frankly shabby. It allows you to get information about new text messages and e-mails in the most unobtrusive way we have ever seen on any mobile device, making it pretty much the killer app for corporate users fed up of loud push e-mail alerts! And no, it does not slow down the device at all. In fact, whatever one may accuse the HTC Magic of, it is certainly not lack of speed—even when we were running four to five applications at the same time, it showed no indication of slowing down.

...but no Android Market!

However, what is missing, catches the eye. The version of HTC Magic released in India does not come with Android Market, that vast reservoir of applications and software for Android phones. And this is because the version of Android running on the device has been tweaked by HTC and is not the official one made by Google—and that is the reason why the back of the device has 'HTC' rather than 'Google' written on it.

The absence of Market is a huge blow to the device as it totally restricts what users can download on to it. Right now, HTC and Airtel have placed five free applications such as weather and stock monitors on the device, but if you are looking for new software, the door is, alas, closed. Even a number of Google's own applications—the Gmail app and Google Maps - are not pre-installed and worse, cannot be installed on the phone. Unlike versions of the device in other markets that also lacked access to Android Market but had other application download websites, the Indian device is largely restricted to what comes on it. Ironically, the phone comes with no mapping solution on it, so the GPS in it is largely restricted to spotting your location for other apps and generating appropriate content. A sad waste!